

political crisis like the one that has emerged in the wake of the Amarnath land transfer will continue to simmer in the Valley ("Fanning the Flames", August 18). Why can't these parties stop playing petty votebank politics?
S. LAKSHMI, *on e-mail*

Divide and rule perhaps sums up the utterly contemptuous behaviour of politicians of all hue in dealing with a matter of national importance ("Divide And Be Damned", August 25). The Government is in a fix—the BJP wants immediate redressal of Hindu loss, Mehbooba Mufti is not in favour of land transfer, which is nothing but "crass political opportunism", and the Hurriyat is spitting venom by infuriating the people. So where does it leave the already-fractured state and the beleaguered nation? On a road to nowhere.
DR NUTAN THAKUR, *Lucknow*

Gun and Glory

Kudos to Abhinav Bindra for winning a gold medal for India at the Beijing Olympics ("Man with a Golden Gun", August 25). The spontaneous outburst of euphoria from millions of admirers that greeted the golden boy on his return is an eloquent tribute to the glory that he brought to his motherland with his victory. Sports serve as an ambassador for peace, solidarity and integration, and Bindra has proved that youthful brilliance, vigour and spirit will reign supreme at the Olympic Games.
D. VINOD, *on e-mail*

Divine Wrath

First at Panchmahal in Gujarat, then at Mata Karauli Temple in Madhya Pradesh, and now at Naina Devi Temple in Himachal Pradesh, many devotees have lost their lives due to stampedes at religious shrines ("Stairway to Death", August 18). This reflects the callous approach of the administrative agencies which refuse to take lessons from tragedies like these. The

Centre should draw up a plan and assist state governments to provide funds and assistance to develop infrastructure—to widen the narrow paths leading to such shrines. The government should also be adequately equipped with a disaster management plan to cope with such untoward occurrences. A special monitoring cell should also be set up by the Ministry of Tourism and Culture for this purpose.
MADHU AGRAWAL, *Delhi*

TERROR CRACKDOWN



A plethora of Acts like TADA and POTA by themselves cannot end terrorism ("The Nation That Failed", August 11). Unless our Government discards pseudo-secularism, minority placation and ensures that terrorists, traitors and anti-nationals are arrested promptly, tried by courts of law expeditiously and those sentenced to death are executed immediately, we shall forever be deemed as a weak-kneed, impotent country. There should be no question of presidential pardon or commutation of death sentence by any agency. It is execution which can serve as a deterrent.

WG. CDR. H.P. HANDE, *Bangalore*

Senior journalist and author M.J. Akbar laments the absence of an all-acceptable Muslim leader ("How Radical is Anger?", August 11). But if he is so concerned about the sad state of affairs, as far as Muslim leadership is concerned, why doesn't he come forward and offer an acceptable solution to solve the problem?

DR SURESH PRASAD, *Lohardaga, Bihar*

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Years Ago in India Today

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Wasnik

Attitude Change

Kunda Wasnik, 25, a bronze-hued, dark eyed, Harijan girl has flown to almost every part of the world except Moscow as an Air-India air hostess. An M.A. in Geography from Nagpur University, she was in two minds about a career in 1976—she could either take to teaching or become an air hostess. She received a call through the Employment Exchange, and was the only one to be selected out of a batch of about 55 applicants for the Air-India job. On the whole, face-to-face with foreigners, she found not a trace of racial discrimination. But initially, in Air-India, there were a few young men who thought she was vulnerable because of her non-English background. "But when they realised that they couldn't impress me, they became themselves." However, she adds, "No one can know by looking at me, but the moment I tell them I'm a Harijan, there's always a certain change in attitude. You can see it."

—Anita Pare